Critical Review: college-majors-trends-2026.md

Source: Review of personal_notes/research/college-majors-trends-2026.md | Date: 2026-05-10

Verdict

The note is unusually strong for this genre — well-sourced, properly skeptical of its own claims, and avoids the typical "here are the hot majors" listicle trap. It synthesizes 79 sources into a coherent framework. The contrarian section and the attrition data are genuine value-adds that most guides ignore.
That said, I found **7 substantive gaps**, **3 factual issues**, and **4 structural weaknesses** that materially affect the advice quality.

I. Factual Issues & Inconsistencies

1. Conflicting CS Decline Numbers — Which Is It?

The note quotes three different figures for the CS decline: - "fell 6% last year after declining 3% in 2024" (TechCrunch, Feb 2026) - "dropped roughly 8 percent in 2026, with the CS major alone falling more than 11 percent" (Metaintro, Apr 2026) - The CRA CERP Survey (Oct 2025) describes undergraduate patterns
The **primary source** — the National Student Clearinghouse Research Center (Feb 10, 2026) — states definitively:

> "Undergraduate enrollment at four-year institutions fell by 8.1% to about 606,000 students. Graduate enrollment dropped sharply by 14.0%, with about 190,000 students." — Student Clearinghouse, "The Changing Landscape of Postsecondary Education," Feb 10, 2026

The TechCrunch "6% system-wide" figure likely includes community colleges (where the decline was 3.6% per Clearinghouse). The Metaintro "8 percent" is close to the correct 8.1% figure. The "11 percent" figure for "the CS major alone" (excluding related information science programs?) is unverified against primary data.
Fix needed: Lead with the 8.1% Clearinghouse figure for four-year undergrads. Distinguish "system-wide" from "four-year" clearly. The current presentation makes it look like there are three different declines when it's really one number measured at different scopes.

2. The "CS Rebound in 3-5 Years" Prediction Lacks Historical Rigor

The note's contrarian conclusion states: "The US CS enrollment decline (8%) + UK decline (3%) + growing AI demand = a likely **CS labor shortage within 3-5 years**."
Historical precedent **contradicts** this timeline:

> "Computer-science enrollments started dropping in 2001, reaching 50% of the 2000 level in 2005, and then staying flat through 2007." — ACM Communications, Nov 2009

> "Interest in computer science (CS) at the university level declined after the 'dot-com bust' of 2000, but then came back with a vengeance in 2007." — Fortune, Oct 2015

> "By 2007, the number of undergraduate CS majors had fallen to half their peak levels." — Ars Technica, Mar 2009

That's a **6-7 year trough** (2001→2007) before recovery began, with degree production lagging further. The current decline started in earnest in fall 2024 (3% drop) and accelerated in fall 2025 (8.1%). If history rhymes, the bottom could be 2028-2030, not 2026-2027. "3-5 years" for a labor shortage is plausible for the *shortage* to emerge, but framing it as "students enrolling now will graduate into a seller's market" is more speculative than stated.

The key difference from dot-com: The current decline is sentiment-driven (AI fear + layoff headlines), not triggered by a massive recession that destroyed the actual demand for engineers. BLS still projects 267,700 new software developer jobs 2024-2034 (Business Insider, Aug 2025) and 317,700 annual openings across all computer/IT occupations (BLS, Aug 2025). This makes the rebound potentially faster — but the note should state this explicitly rather than just asserting "3-5 years."

3. The Biomedical Sciences Figure Is Stale

The note says: "Biological/Biomedical Sciences — steady growth, ~126,000 degrees/year by 2020."
Current data tells a different story:

> "Undergraduate enrollment in biomedical majors rose to nearly 642,500, increasing 3.7% in 2025 compared to 3.1% in 2024." — STAT News, Jan 15, 2026

That's not 126,000 degrees — that's 642,500 *enrolled students*. The note conflates degrees awarded (an older NCES figure) with current enrollment. The field is far larger and growing faster than the note implies. Biomedical/biological sciences enrollment growth (3.7%) outpaced the overall undergraduate average (1.2%) in 2025.

II. Major Gaps (Missing Content)

Gap 1: The Accounting/CPA Crisis — Arguably the Biggest Hidden Opportunity

This is a *glaring* omission. The note mentions accounting as NACE #4 (58% of firms hiring) and says "CPA shortage" in the summary matrix, but completely fails to document what is one of the most acute professional labor shortages in the US:

> "The accounting profession lost over 300,000 professionals between 2020 and 2024. The pipeline replacing them has shrunk by roughly 33% over the past decade. AICPA data shows that accounting degree completions have dropped for the eighth consecutive year, hitting levels not seen since the early 2000s." — Madras Accountancy, Apr 2026

> "The number of people sitting for the CPA exam has declined by more than 30 percent since 2016." — Wall Street Journal, 2025 (via Talentfoot, Mar 2026)

> "83 percent of financial leaders said they could not find qualified accounting talent — up from 70 percent in 2022." — CFO Pulse Survey 2024 (via UC Davis, Jul 2025)

> "At least seven states — Indiana, Georgia, Ohio, Virginia, New Mexico, Utah, and Hawaii — have passed or enacted laws in 2025 that would allow aspiring accountants to trade some tuition costs for a working paycheck on their paths to obtaining a CPA license." — Empower, May 4, 2026

The accounting crisis has the same structural shape as nursing: massive boomer retirements + declining pipeline + rising demand. But accounting offers **higher earnings** ($72K starting for finance, per the note's own data) with **lower attrition** (no calculus/physics gauntlet) and **more flexibility** (every industry needs accountants). States are literally changing their laws to make the path easier.
For a high schooler with modest math ability who wants financial security, accounting/finance may be the single best risk-adjusted bet right now — and the note barely mentions it.

Gap 2: Federal Student Loan Policy Overhaul (The SAVE Plan Is Dead)

The note discusses tuition discounting and the demographic cliff but completely ignores the single biggest change to the financial calculus of college in 2026:

> "On March 10, 2026, the U.S. Court of Appeals for the Eighth Circuit officially eliminated the SAVE plan — the Biden-era income-driven repayment program that offered the lowest monthly payments of any federal repayment option in history." — StudentChoice.org, Apr 28, 2026

> "Beginning this summer, the Department will implement commonsense loan limits on how much students and parents can borrow, simplify the current patchwork of repayment options, establish a new, congressionally authorized income-driven repayment plan." — U.S. Dept. of Education, Apr 30, 2026

> "Some changes went into effect immediately in July 2025, like expanded access to the Income Based Repayment (IBR) plan. Others will roll out between 2026 and 2028, including the launch of a new repayment plan and new borrowing caps." — UMD Extension, Mar 2026

This matters enormously for major selection because: - **New borrowing caps** mean some students literally cannot finance expensive programs - The death of SAVE removes the "safety net" of low payments for low-earning majors (humanities, arts, social work) - The new RAP plan caps payments at 1-10% of AGI — less generous than SAVE's terms - 7+ million borrowers are being forced to switch plans by September 2026 - The "pursue your passion and use income-driven repayment" strategy is no longer viable in the same way
This directly intersects with the note's socioeconomic stratification point: low-income students relying on loans now face a harsher repayment landscape, making ROI-focused major choices even more critical.

Gap 3: The "Great Reinstatement" of Standardized Testing

The admissions landscape section is completely absent from this note, despite admissions being the *gateway* to major selection. A massive shift is underway:

> "For the 2026-2027 admissions cycle, Harvard, Yale, Dartmouth, Brown, Cornell, Caltech, and MIT all require SAT or ACT scores. Only Columbia and Princeton remain test-optional among Ivy League schools, and Princeton has already announced it will reinstate testing for 2027-2028." — Oriel Admissions, Apr 2026

> "Major public flagships including LSU, Auburn, the University of Alabama, and the entire Florida and Georgia public university systems are phasing in testing requirements for 2027 admissions." — The College Investor, Apr 2026

> "At test-optional schools in 2026, 70% to 80% of admitted students still submitted SAT or ACT scores." — Oriel Admissions (citing Common Data Sets 2024-2025), Apr 2026

> "Data from the Common App shows an 11% year-over-year increase [in score submissions], the largest single-year jump since test-optional policies began." — Forbes, Mar 2026

This matters for major choice because: - Test-required policies at elite schools affect who gets access to top engineering/CS/business programs - Engineering and CS programs at selective schools have higher admit test score floors - The reinstatement disproportionately affects first-gen students who benefited from test-optional

Gap 4: The Internship Pipeline (The Actual Hiring Mechanism)

The note mentions internships in passing ("supplement with internships") but never quantifies the dominant hiring mechanism for new graduates:

> "On average, employers extended offers of full-time employment to 62% of their 2024 intern class." — NACE, Aug 2025

> "NACE's annual survey of internship employers has consistently found that 50% to 60% of eligible interns convert to full-time employees." — NACE Position Statement

> "While hourly pay dipped marginally this year, the long-term trend remains positive—averaging $24.46." — NACE via UW-Madison, Apr 2026

> "However, overall intern hiring is expected to fall 3.1%." — NACE, 2026

The internship conversion pipeline is **the** primary mechanism through which major choice converts to employment. A CS major without internships has dramatically different outcomes than one with two summers at a tech company. An engineering major at a school without co-op programs faces a completely different job market than one at Northeastern or Drexel. The note treats "major" as the unit of analysis, but **major + internship experience** is the actual signal employers use.

Gap 5: Public Health — The Fastest-Growing Major Nobody Discusses

Completely absent from the top-10 list and the analysis:

> "The number of undergraduate public health majors has skyrocketed over the past two decades" growing by "more than 1,000 percent." — Inside Higher Ed, Jan 2023

> "Undergraduate enrollment in [UCI's public health school] has increased by about 21% in the past six years while its Master of Public Health has jumped by more than 300%." — UC Irvine, May 2025

But the picture is now *complicated* by politics:

> "'The class of 2025 graduated into one of the worst public health job markets I've seen.' Since President Donald Trump reassumed office, the United States has endured a flurry of governmental blows to public health and science in general, including job losses and budget cuts at federal agencies; slashing of research grant funding; the dissolution of USAID; and a retreat from evidence-based policies." — Think Global Health, Dec 2025

This is a cautionary tale the note misses entirely: **political risk** is a real factor in major choice. Federal policy changes can crater a field's job market within months. Public health, environmental science, and education are all exposed to this risk right now.

Gap 6: Career Satisfaction — The Metric Nobody Optimizes

The note is almost exclusively economic (salary, unemployment, underemployment). But:

> "Among degree holders, STEM and business majors reported the highest earnings, and humanities and social sciences majors reported lower salaries alongside **higher job relevance and stronger career satisfaction scores**." — Frontiers in Education, May 2, 2026

This is a genuine tension the note ignores. A humanities major earning $50K who rates their career satisfaction at 8/10 may have higher lifetime *utility* than an engineering major earning $90K who hates their job and burns out. The note's framework is purely economic — which is defensible for practical advice, but should be explicitly acknowledged as a limitation.

Gap 7: Graduate School as Decision Point

The note says "needs grad school" for biology and psychology but never discusses the graduate school landscape itself:

- 3.2 million graduate students in fall 2025 (National Student Clearinghouse)
- 62.3% enrolled part-time (ZipDo, Feb 2026)
- Online graduate enrollment grew 21% from 2021-2022
- Graduate applications increased 11% from 2021 to 2023
- Computing graduate enrollment dropped 14% in fall 2025

For fields like biology, psychology, and public health, the relevant question isn't "should I major in this?" — it's "am I prepared to commit to 6-8 more years of education after my bachelor's?" The note's advice on these majors is incomplete without discussing the graduate school calculus: opportunity cost, funded vs. unfunded programs, terminal master's vs. PhD, and the adjunct crisis in academia.

III. Structural Weaknesses

1. The Note Buries the Lede on BLS Software Developer Data

The note says: "Software developers: Still growing in absolute terms despite saturation at entry level."
The *actual* BLS data is far more striking:

> "Software developer employment is projected to grow by 267,700 from 2024 to 2034." — Business Insider, Aug 2025 (citing BLS)

> "Overall employment in computer and information technology occupations is projected to grow much faster than the average for all occupations from 2024 to 2034. About 317,700 openings are projected each year, on average." — BLS, Aug 2025

That's 317,700 annual openings against ~170,000 CS graduates per year (and now declining). The math *already* favors CS grads in aggregate — the problem is distribution (concentration in SWE at FAANG, geographic clustering, credential inflation at top employers). The note's doom-inflected framing on CS, while attention-grabbing, undersells the fundamental supply-demand reality that BLS projects.

2. The UNF Retention Data Is Misleadingly Specific

Using University of North Florida (a regional state school, US News #263-305) as representative of engineering attrition is problematic. The 37-42% four-year graduation rates for EE/ME at UNF are real but extreme. The note acknowledges "top engineering schools have 90%+ retention" but leads with the UNF data, creating a misleading impression.

National ASEE data would be more appropriate as the anchor, with UNF as the illustrative worst case. The ASEE/ASME "approximately 50%" figure is the national average — meaning many schools are between 50-90%, not 37%.

3. No Discussion of "Impacted" vs. "Open" Admissions by Major

The note mentions UIUC's College of Business (20.9% admit rate) in one tip, but never systematically addresses a crucial reality: **not all majors are equally accessible.** At many state flagships: - Engineering: 15-30% admit rate - CS: 10-20% admit rate (at places like UIUC, where CS admits at ~6%) - Nursing: Highly competitive (80K rejected applicants cited) - Business: Moderately competitive - Arts & Sciences: Much higher admit rates A high schooler reading this note might conclude "choose engineering" without understanding that at their target school, the admit rate for engineering might be 3-4x harder than Liberal Arts. The note should include a section on differential admissions by major and how to navigate it.

4. The Note Assumes a Monolithic "High Schooler" Audience

The socioeconomic stratification section is excellent but comes too late and is too brief. The first-gen student reading tip #6 ("T-shaped strategy") faces different constraints than the prep school student at Exeter. The entire "Practical Tips" section should be segmented by student profile: - Elite-bound students (targeting T20) - State flagship students - Community college starters - Trade/technical path students - First-gen navigators Different audiences need different advice. Telling everyone to "play schools against each other" or "apply undeclared to Arts & Sciences" only works for middle-class students with multiple competitive offers.

IV. Minor Issues

1. **"Business is #1 since 1980"** — This is approximately true but NCES data shows Health Professions briefly overtook Business in 2019-2020. The note should say "nearly always #1 since 1980."
2. **The UK comparison section is thin.** The 3% decline in UK computing enrollment and the BCS quote are fine, but the note could note that other countries (India, China) are *increasing* CS enrollment dramatically, which affects the global labor market through outsourcing and remote work.
3. **The note doesn't mention online degrees/non-traditional paths** as a growing competitor. Online enrollment grew 21% at the graduate level. WGU and SNHU enroll over 200K+ students each. For some fields (IT, cybersecurity, business), online completion programs offer a faster, cheaper path that traditional major-choice advice doesn't address.
4. **No mention of dual enrollment/AP credit** as a factor in major completion. Students arriving with 30+ AP credits can graduate in 3 years or double-major more easily — changing the math on the "5-6 years for engineering" concern.

V. What the Note Gets Exceptionally Right

To be fair — several sections are stronger than anything I've seen in published advice:

1. **The CS paradox framing** (high unemployment + highest salary + lowest underemployment) is genuinely insightful and correctly sourced.
2. **The data science skepticism** (968% from near-zero base, 4% of job postings require the degree specifically) is correct and rarely stated.
3. **The engineering attrition warning** — most guides say "go STEM" without acknowledging 50% don't finish.
4. **The demographic cliff as leverage** — connecting enrollment decline to negotiating power is smart and actionable.
5. **The Rutgers "two-way street" finding** — that as many students move INTO STEM as leave it — is a crucial correction to the "leaky pipeline" narrative.
6. **The "AI-proof ≠ well-paid" reframe** is the single best insight in the entire note.

Summary of Recommended Additions

Gap	Priority	Effort
Accounting/CPA crisis	**HIGH** — massive hidden opportunity, directly actionable	Medium
Federal loan policy (SAVE death, borrowing caps)	**HIGH** — changes the financial calculus for everyone	Medium
Internship pipeline quantification	**HIGH** — it's THE hiring mechanism	Low
Standardized testing reinstatement	**MEDIUM** — affects access to competitive programs	Low
Public health (rise + political risk)	**MEDIUM** — cautionary tale about policy risk	Low
Graduate school landscape	**MEDIUM** — affects bio/psych/public health advice	Medium
Career satisfaction data	**LOW** — philosophical but less actionable	Low
Segment tips by student profile	**MEDIUM** — structural improvement	High
BLS software developer numbers (317K/yr openings)	**HIGH** — directly contradicts doom framing	Low
Fix CS decline number to 8.1% primary source	**HIGH** — factual accuracy	Low

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